

herself to the washroom. That is when Joe gets an urgent call from office regarding a design of his that had fallen apart during prototyping. He joins the virtual room using his portable VR glasses and quickly points out the missing parts to the prototyping team. He puts away the glasses just in time for his wife to be back.

- ♦ **9:00pm:** Both of them leave the restaurant and head over to the beach road to experience the beauty of the sea and the night sky. Without VR for a change, because some things just can't be simulated.

Distorting Reality

"With great power, comes great responsibility" - Uncle Ben (Spiderman)

The virtual selves that we seem to be headed towards will have far greater powers than we do. They would not be restricted by an aging body, nor would they be forced to heed the laws of physics. Their limits would not be defined by gravity, oxygen, hunger, fatigue or things that affect our bodies. Yet every sensation and feeling that a human body can feel, can be felt by the virtual body. This has some worrying consequences.

For example, what makes a crime in virtual reality? When you are hitting another person in a VR experience, and that person is feeling the pain in real life, are you committing a crime? Maybe not, because that person was willing put on all the devices required to feel that pain fully knowing the possibility of being hit in the game. But by that logic, the concept of explicit consent vanishes in virtual reality.

We are already concerned with the smartphones and headphones taking over our lives with human to human interaction reducing every day. A future with full VR capabilities will put this phenomenon on steroids. The movie 'Surrogates' showed humans as a race of connected controllers that existed via puppet bodies and did not move from their place. It was evident that this was physically destroying the human race and had taken away an essential part of being alive from their lives.

Even if we remove the possibility of being connected to an actual body or being able to feel any pain or touch, VR is still a highly immersive experience. Any violent actions or disturbing experiences within VR can affect the brain in identical ways to real life, perhaps even more effectively. What enhances this danger is the fact that perpetrators could disconnect themselves after the incident and disappear behind the anonymity of the internet.

Forget all the negative and worrisome topics we just mentioned. Just consider a normal human life in a VR world. Would a soldier who knows